hub for ingoing investment as well as massive outgoing legal and illicit capital flight.

A similar situation prevails in Latin America. Brazil's affiliations with the progressive governments of the so-called 'Pink Tide' haven't prevented it from pursuing an aggressive programme of transnationalising its biggest firms – securing resources and markets across the continent. The vanguard of Chinese and Brazilian capital's penetration of the Global South has been the national development bank – both of which at this point are larger than the World Bank in terms of lending. Unlike the case of Western-dominated institutions, Chinese lending hasn't come with 'structural adjustments' – demands for pro-market economic policy to ensure repayment. Instead it is typically attached to agreements to source inputs and labour from other Chinese companies. China gets a double deal – interest payments and the biggest share of the economic activity generated by the loan. The benefits and multiplier effects for loaning nations are typically limited. The victims are African and Latin American citizenries whose authoritarian leaders now have more staying power. As China grows in size and developing economies become increasingly dependent on its markets and exports, there are signs that Chinese demands are growing increasingly onerous and starting to impinge on the sovereignty of lending nations in the same way that Washington's Bretton Woods institutions have historically done.

There is little reason to see why a BRICS NDB dedicated to infrastructure lending wouldn't be instrumentalised in the same way and directed to lubricate the extraction of minerals and oil, or to engage in other dubious, destructive mega-projects that even the World Bank no longer touches as a result of civil society protest. There is also little evidence that peripheral nations are absorbing technologies or other developmental assets from these burgeoning exchanges with emerging powers. In short, Eastern and Southern exploitation often looks little different from Northern, except that we have to work much harder to establish solidarity relations as a counterbalance, given oppressive regimes in China and Russia which brook no complaining.

BRICS claims to talk for the Global South in a historical vision of 'convergence' under a 'new world order' are thus rather hollow. The logical end point of the current trajectory is that new imperialist powers will stalk the globe and compete for its resources, not an alternative to capitalism's extremely uneven development – if it gets that far, that is. The literature on shifting power balances is filled with confident predictions about the exact point that East overtakes West (2030? 2050?) as the economic centre of the world. Recall how Japan was going to be the next hegemon – until it crashed in 1990, never to stand up straight again.